



CLUE & CANDLE GAMES PRESENTS



SOLUTION · HOST ONLY

# The Secret Santa Murder

*An Office Christmas Party Murder Mystery Game*

8-40 PLAYERS

TEAM PLAY

60 MIN OR 2 HRS

PRINTABLE PDF

*STOP. Host only.  
Do not open until the reveal.*



CLUE & CANDLE GAMES

US LETTER + A4 · 23 PDFs

# The Solution

HOST ONLY



## Rowan Pike, Finance Lead · CORE SUSPECT · BOOKLET 11

### HOW

Rowan tampered with a tin of Maple Street fudge, boxed it in midnight blue with a printed tag, and at about 3:40 pm, during the toast, swapped it for Bart's real gift (Parker's green box).

### WHY

Rowan invented "Northstar Ribbon Supply" and approved 14 invoices for ribbon that never came. Bart found out and planned to tell Walt on Monday.

## ❄ The clue chain: 6 steps

| # | STEP                                     | WHAT PROVES IT                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | EVIDENCE              |
|---|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| 1 | <b>The gift was swapped</b>              | Bart's real Secret Santa gift, Parker's green box, was found unopened behind the coat rack. At 3:35 pm the green box was on the table; by 3:52 a midnight-blue box with a printed tag had replaced it. The swap happened during the toast. | <b>E3, G1, E1, E2</b> |
| 2 | <b>The swapper wore a scarf</b>          | At 3:40 pm someone at the gift table was re-taping a box, wearing a scarf. The Cast List shows only three suspects wearing scarves: Kendall Brooks, Rowan Pike and Emerson Gray.                                                           | <b>G2, Cast List</b>  |
| 3 | <b>Only one scarf-wearer was missing</b> | The 3:42 pm toast photo shows Kendall (front row) and Emerson (at the microphone) in the main hall. Rowan Pike is not in the photo.                                                                                                        | <b>E5</b>             |
| 4 | <b>Rowan's alibi falls apart</b>         | Rowan's calendar says a budget call in the Finance office until 4:00, but the phone log shows a 58-second call at 3:30, and at 3:40 the office was dark and locked.                                                                        | <b>E8, E10, G3</b>    |
| 5 | <b>Rowan paid for the fudge</b>          | The tin came from Maple Street Bakery, packed Dec 18. The Dec 18 receipt was paid with card 4417, which the register lists as the Finance card held by Rowan Pike.                                                                         | <b>E7, E6, E9</b>     |
| 6 | <b>Rowan had the motive</b>              | Bart's note: 14 Northstar invoices, zero deliveries, "Talk to R.P.", Walt on Monday. The Northstar invoice is approved by R. Pike, and the warehouse never received a single Northstar box.                                                | <b>E11, E12, G4</b>   |

Every step uses only evidence cards (30), guest cards (21) and the public Cast List (04).

# Why Not the Others?

NINE INNOCENT SUSPECTS

| SUSPECT                | RED HERRING AND WHY THEY ARE CLEARED                                                                                                             |
|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Avery Quill</b>     | Moved the boxes at 3:15 and took fudge off the menu, but Bart's box was still green at 3:35 (G1), and Avery is in the 3:42 photo (E5). No scarf. |
| <b>Jesse Marlow</b>    | Bought fudge for a photo shoot, but from Snowcap Sweets in a white box (G8), not Maple Street (E7). In the 3:42 photo (E5). No scarf.            |
| <b>Kendall Brooks</b>  | Argued with Bart and wears a red scarf, but stood in the front row of the 3:42 photo (E5) beside Bart.                                           |
| <b>Parker Lane</b>     | Missing from the photo, but was in the server room with Casey 3:30–3:55 (G5, E8). The green box was Parker's own gift (E3).                      |
| <b>Emerson Gray</b>    | Wears a scarf and holds master keys, but was at the microphone 3:35–3:50, in the photo (E2, E5).                                                 |
| <b>Skyler Moss</b>     | Changed the sign-up sheet for Bart, but was taking the 3:42 photo from the back of the hall (E5, G19).                                           |
| <b>Drew Calder</b>     | Missing from the photo, but was in the kitchen the whole toast (G6), and fudge wasn't on the menu (E4).                                          |
| <b>Reese Whitfield</b> | Gave Bart a silver tin (G18), still unopened in Bart's pocket; in the 3:42 photo (E5). Bart's note says R.P., not R.W.                           |
| <b>Finley Dale</b>     | Has spare desk keys, but stood beside Walt in the 3:42 photo (E5). Card 4417 isn't Finley's (E9).                                                |

## MOTIVES AT A GLANCE

Avery: blocked promotion · Jesse: stolen campaign · Kendall: stolen account · Parker: blamed for Black Friday · Emerson: threatened job · Skyler: lost job offer · Drew: unpaid invoice · Reese: broken deal · Finley: family shares · **Rowan: hidden invoices**

# Script 5 • The Reveal

READ SLOWLY, WITH PAUSES

*[Collect all ballots first. Microphone on.]*

Thank you, detectives. Every ballot is in, and it is time for the truth. Let's start with the gift table. Bart's real Secret Santa gift, a little succulent from Parker, was found unopened behind the coat rack. At 3:35 it was on the table. By 3:52 a midnight-blue box had taken its place. Someone swapped them during the toast.

A colleague saw that someone at 3:40, re-taping a box in the dim hallway, wearing a scarf. Three suspects wore scarves tonight: Kendall, Emerson and Rowan. But the toast photo puts Kendall in the front row and Emerson at the microphone. Only one scarf was missing from that photo.

Rowan Pike said they were on a budget call. The phone log says that call lasted fifty-eight seconds, and at 3:40 the Finance office was dark and locked. The fudge tin came from Maple Street Bakery, and the receipt was paid with card 4417: the Finance card, held by Rowan.

And the reason? Bart had found fourteen invoices from Northstar Ribbon Supply, a supplier that never delivered a single spool of ribbon, every one approved by R. Pike. Bart planned to tell Walt on Monday morning. Rowan Pike, please stand up.

Rowan, would you like to say a few words?

*[Let Rowan respond. Then:]*

The case is closed. Let's see which team followed the evidence best!

# Scoring & Awards

HOST ONLY

| BALLOT LINE  | CORRECT ANSWER                                                                                                                                                   | POINTS         |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| Who          | Rowan Pike                                                                                                                                                       | 5              |
| How          | Swapped Bart's gift for a midnight-blue box of tampered peppermint fudge during the toast (about 3:40 pm). Accept any answer naming the fudge and the gift swap. | 2              |
| Why          | To stop Bart exposing the fake Northstar Ribbon Supply invoices on Monday. Accept "money", "fraud" or "the invoices".                                            | 3              |
| Evidence     | Any two of: E1, E2, E3, E5, E6, E7, E8, E9, E10, E11, E12, G1, G2, G3, G4                                                                                        | 1 each (max 2) |
| <b>Total</b> |                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>12</b>      |

Ties: the team that handed in its ballot first wins. At 8–10 players, score individual ballots the same way.

## ❄ Award ceremony (file 34)

1. **Best Detective Team:** highest score. Read the team's name and its two evidence numbers aloud.
2. **Best Performance:** a quick show of hands for the most convincing suspect. Rowan is eligible: staying calm under pressure counts!
3. **Most Festive Accessory:** applause vote, or the host's choice.

### WRAPPING UP

Thank the suspects and helpers by name, invite everyone back to the cocoa bar, and collect the evidence cards if you want to reuse the game next year. Merry Christmas from Clue & Candle Games!